

University of California, Berkeley 4

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I'm Jennifer, I'm a first year MBA student. So we're really excited to have Rachel join us today. Just to give a brief intro before we get started, Rachel Wolin is the Chief Product Officer at Webflow and oversees the company's product, design, and insights teams.

As Webflow continues its mission to democratize web development, she's excited to drive innovation and continue expanding the platform's capabilities, making it even easier for people to collaborate and bring their web experiences to life. Rachel has been passionate about web development since she was a teenager, a passion rooted in her early career building websites for a wide range of clients, including Taco Bell and her friends, fan, Future Rock. Please join me in welcoming Rachel to Haas.

I also would like to add that Rachel is also a Haas alum. So just to get us started, you worked across more mature companies such as Dropbox, and now you are at a hyperscale company at Webflow. What were the most important career decisions that set you up for a CPO role? Yeah, I think it depends on kind of like which stage you're at, right? So I started my career as a software engineer and actually made that transition to being a product manager when I came to Haas.

And even at that point, it was kind of like, is this a good decision? I was living in Chicago, I had this like well-paying job, but it was like, is this actually a good decision? And I think a lot of times you have to take that leap. And it's a leap of faith in a lot of ways. But ultimately, I always think that the best data set is your gut.

And so the more you can actually like understand and kind of like cultivate your gut, the better off you're going to be. And so, you know, what I've always looked at is, are there ways that I can scale myself up? And are there ways that I can scale myself down? And what is the right thing at that moment? And I think right now, we're at a moment where it's good to be able to scale yourself down in a lot of ways because people want builders. And I think no matter what discipline you're in, whether you're in product or you're in finance, you know, even when you're in engineering, people want builders.

And so I think this is kind of a moment where you have to kind of be very good at being both a super I.C. and being able to kind of like hook your head up out of the weeds and like get that view. I love what you said about how you have to keep building. So you call yourself a builder first and an executive second.

I'd love to know, as the chief product officer, how do you actively carve out time for hands-on product thinking to keep your intuition sharp and always keep building? Yeah. You know, I would say this year has probably been the year where I've written the most code since I was a software engineer. And luckily, my job, so Webflow is a website platform.

You can build, manage, and optimize your website on Webflow. And so first and foremost, I get to actually build products. I get to launch websites just as like my day job.

So I think that's always something nice to make sure that your day job includes building. But then I think also for me, this year I've spent a lot of time really trying to think about how can I try to scale things that are happening in my team where I can actually be building on top of whatever my team is building. So, for example, we went through a heavy documentation of our data set this year.

And that means that I can go and use the Snowflake MCP through Cloud Code in order to be able to ask questions like it's a data scientist. A big part of that is kind of knowing like what are all the pieces that need to kind of come together. But, you know, and I didn't start here.

I started building, you know, prompting a lovable app, you know, like a year and a half ago when they first came out. And then just kind of like continuing to build. The second thing that I really tried to do is instill that builder culture in my team.

And so like yesterday we actually – or this week we had a builder day. And so that meant that, you know, my admin did not want me to, but I was like no meetings today. Like I'm just going to code all day.

And I think that's the way you do it. You just like say no meetings today. I'm just going to do this.

And then, you know, nights and weekends I also work on side projects. So like right before I came here I was working on a side project to basically take all the learnings from our builder day and publish a website that's a builder day in a box so that everybody can go and use that. My wife has a startup.

It's called shirts.com with two R's, S-H-I-R-R-T-S.com. It's an AI t-shirt generator. I work on her, you know, app with her. So I just try to find ways to keep my hands dirty.

And, you know, it's not like always perfect. And I think a lot of times it's something that's just for me. I think we're in this moment where you actually can go and very, very easily just build software for yourself.

So you did talk a lot about how you have been using AI to help you like propel your building. I'd love to know though now that AI can generate layouts or code, what do you believe becomes a human differentiator that requires unique judgment and taste? Yeah, I mean, I think it's the best time in the entire, like, history of time to be a builder. Because, number one, as a product manager, we – so, for example, at this offsite that we had this week, it was, you know, kind of a virtual offsite, we – there were 86 people that published repos and published prototypes.

And they had to decide what to build and why. So a lot of, you know, like, I think that business people are actually more important now. And I think that what engineers are going to do is

really about architecting a solution or understanding what, you know, how the pieces fit together.

And so I think critical thinking skills and creativity become so much more important than ever before. And then also understanding how to get distribution. How do you actually get people – find people to discover your product? And I think that's just marketing 101, right? But I think that what's interesting about it is that new marketing channels are opening up right now.

So, you know, in our case, who in here knows what answer engine optimization is? Okay, like, I'll give you – so answer engine optimization, I'm assuming everyone has used ChatsVT in here. So you put in a question, and then you put in another question, and the answers come back. Those answers are pre-trained off of – the LLM is basically pre-trained, and then it will also go out and inference and basically, like, read websites.

You can have them. Like, we'll read hundreds of websites to get an answer. That is a brand-new distribution and discovery engine, right, that all of you can go and learn about.

And so I think we're just at this, like, beautiful moment where, you know, the thing that is going to be scarce is good ideas, which have always been pretty scarce. And understanding the customer is still really scarce. That is hard.

Like, trying to understand – because a customer is not one person. It's hundreds of people or millions of people or thousands of people, right? And so I think that intuition, again, like, populating your gut is still an extremely important skill. How would you recommend, then, for those of us that are aspiring product managers to go about, like, developing that gut? I'm sure it doesn't just come, like, out of nowhere.

Like, how do you get the reps in to actually develop that? You just get the reps in naturally. No, I mean, I don't think I was very good at it when I was here. I think that it took, like, a lot of time to – a lot of it was picking a problem that I thought was a problem worth solving.

And then going and talking to people who have that problem. And then realizing that the way that I thought that they had the problem was wrong. And then showing them something.

And now it's so easy to go and show a prototype to someone and, like, get that – that you can kind of reduce that feedback loop in a much, much faster way. And so I think that the best thing to do is go and start a company. Go and, like, build something for somebody who you think has a problem and solve that problem for them.

And it's just, like, a really magical moment when you've actually solved someone's problem. So that would probably be the first thing I would do. The second thing I would probably go do is find a startup to go work on.

I think working in startups, like, you will run through walls. And sometimes you even shouldn't run through that wall. And you kind of realize that you, like, went too far through that wall.

And then you have to back up and be like, okay, I need to find a new wall to run through. And so I think that it's really – you know, I think it is kind of like taste. Like, taste knows taste.

But then it's like, well, how do you get taste? It's like, well, you know, maybe you had some, like, flops at different times. You sort of, like, understand when those flops happened. So it's hard to say, like, how exactly to do it.

But I would say pick a problem and go and learn everything you possibly can about that problem. Okay, I love that. And I know we were just talking about this, but a lot of us now have a lot of time.

So this is also – Rachel and I were just talking about how this is the perfect time to do that. So I love that advice. I wanted to shift the discussion a little bit to your time at Webflow so far.

Has there been a counterintuitive decision you've made along the journey of your time at Webflow that proved to be critical to success? And how did that journey go in executing on that? Yeah, I think we're in this, like – I'll give a little bit of context about Webflow. So Webflow started 12 years ago. So this was pre-AI, you know, animated or generative AI.

And we really had to go through that reinvention over the last couple of years. We had exactly zero AI products when I joined. I joined two years ago.

And I think that there are a couple of things that we have done over the last year. Like, you know, first of all, we are in a category that got tremendously disrupted in the last year. We have Lovable and vZero and Bolts and, like, the other, you know, 12 towards that entered this category and got, like, you know, \$200 million in funding.

And so the best part of our business became Red Ocean. But where we actually had made place a pretty big bet and had already gotten a lot of reps in was starting to move up market. And that was Blue Ocean for us, right? Like, you know, I think a lot of times there's all these sexy companies that are moving to your space and people are like, oh, my God, how are you still surviving? And, in fact, the companies that we're actually competing against that are really durable businesses, you know, content management systems in large marketing companies, right, that have, you know, hundreds or thousands of people that are actually editing their content and need guardrails and need kind of an enterprise-grade solution and, you know, need, like, whatever, 491 availability, like, all the things that you want in enterprise software, we had actually invested in over the last year or so.

And I think that the biggest kind of, like, counterintuitive bet that we placed was that we were going to have to let, you know, basically a part of our business go in order to be able to go after the healthy part of our business. And then, you know, just continuing to also realize that there's, like, waves come in sets. And so while we might have gotten disrupted in one part of our business, the next wave was coming.

And that next wave, we're basically in the middle of catching right now. It's really a lot of these

companies are getting disrupted by answer engines. So, you know, all companies are getting disrupted by the fact that answer engines are kind of moving away.

You know, traditionally, websites got discovered through search. They got discovered through ads. And now answer engines are really disrupting where their customers and potential prospects are coming from.

And so we're kind of at that moment. We're the thought leader in that space. This is like, you know, I had, like, one of the founders yelling at me, being like, you shouldn't invest in this space.

I was like, yes, we should. Like, this is the future. And now we're kind of at this moment where now there's, like, ten companies in the last six months that have gotten funded in the answer engine optimization space.

We also made a bunch of bets around, you know, I think, like, the kinds of companies that we're competing against are, like, 30-year-old companies like Adobe and Sitecore. Sitecore is a company that literally is still on-prem, and they're big innovations. They're moving on to cloud.

Whereas we're in this, like, leapfrog moment that is really like an AI native moment and kind of reinventing what that means for marketing teams and how they actually, you know, show up for their organizations. So to talk a little bit more about that, given Webflow's mission to bring development superpowers to everyone and the pace that AI is moving at, how do you see Webflow maintaining a competitive mode given all the competitors in the market right now? Yeah, I mean, I think it depends on which competitor. Like, we're actually seen as the challenger in the upmarket.

But I think what we've also done is try to protect ourselves on the downside. So this week we actually launched an AppGen product. The AppGen product is quite different than what any of our competitors launched.

And sometimes it's good to come from behind, right? Like, there are a lot of companies in Web 1.0 and Web 2.0 and Web 3.0 that were the first to market. You know, no one in this room probably remembers, like, Path. Path was, like, a very buzzy company when I was in business school.

That company doesn't exist anymore. That was, like, one of the first web app, like, mobile social networks. And so I think that what's interesting is that you don't necessarily have to be first to market, even with AI.

I think there are companies that will obviously be extremely dominant in this industry that are first to market. But I also think that, you know, if you have a credible solution, like, for us, we looked at all of these prototyping companies. The Lovables, for example.

And, you know, quite frankly, we lost some market share to them. But the thing that people

complain about, again, a lot of this is, like, what do people complain about for the existing solution market? And I think that's also, like, an interesting thing to go do if you're, like, trying to get an internship. Go and talk to, like, ten users of a product of that company that you are trying to go and get a job at and bring, like, they're like, I did some analysis of maybe your website.

You can go, like, actually talk to users that are talking about publicly on that. And, you know, we were like, oh, it's all prototypes. People are not actually able to launch production.

There's a lot of security issues. And it doesn't look anything like their brand. Right? It's not using their brand design system.

And that was, like, what we set out as, like, our goal to be the differentiation when we went to market. And if you go and look at our launch this week, it was all about productive production. And so having kind of that north star of, like, what is wrong with the solution that's in market that, honestly, they're kind of, like, anchored to right now.

That's how you end up really starting to, like, leapfrog again. But I'm sure we'll get leapfrogged again. Like, you can't stop.

I think that's the key thing I would say is, like, you can't actually stop. You have to just kind of understand that, like, someone else is going to come after that value prop as well. Yeah.

Makes a lot of sense. To talk a little bit more about Webflow's customers. So Webflow serves both creators, who typically maybe some are not coders, as well as professional developers.

How does Webflow go about prioritizing between those two segments, which often have conflicting needs for ease versus control, as AI empowers non-coders even more? That's a great question. I'll tell a funny story from this week. So we did this AppGen launch, and AppGen as a product, I think it's a product where we don't know exactly who's going to use it yet.

I think that has been, like, one of the biggest challenges for us because we have so many different segments. Now, what we found was that the professional creators were like, well, I would never use this as a client, but, oh, it's really helpful for prototyping. So for them, it actually, we didn't quite meet the market.

I was like, okay. For a lot of people who are marketers who have no design capabilities, they're like, oh, my God, I can prompt an app. I can create a pricing calculator or run some tests.

This is amazing. And I had a 4 1/2. There was one of our agency partners.

Suddenly, he lit me up, and he was like, I wasn't going to do it publicly, and blah, blah, blah. But, you know, he is so passionate about our company and our community and our platform, and he's built an entire identity and his entire livelihood on our platform. He's like, wait, you're, like, this is not going in the right direction.

Why would you put something out there that is, you know, that is, like, in beta? Like, this doesn't meet my expectations. You overpromised and underdelivered. And I was like, this was intentional.

Like, we did this intentionally because we wanted to see what people were going to build on our platform. And so we've had to even change the way that we release products for AI and also know that, like, it's not going to beat the bar for every segment right out of the gate. But we do have AI products that are for that professional segment.

So a lot of this is really, like, how far along do we think we are and where the market is for a particular segment? So, I mean, we work with, you know, and then it's also, like, how comfortable are they and how much have they adopted AI at this point as well? Like, developers who are a freelancer or even, like, a small agency, they've heavily adopted AI because it makes them, like, 100x more effective. And so he's like, oh, this isn't a ghost cursor. And I'm like, no shit.

I'm like, that's not what we're going for. But, you know, I think that's always the, you know, the tension when you're building. And a big part of this is, like, the thing that we do best is really interoperability and building solutions that work well for designers, that work with developers, that work with marketers.

And so we still have a long way to go. And a lot of this, you know, like, me falling on the floor and being like, don't worry, we are going to get this to the place where you want it to be. But I think it's, like, you know, it's hard.

Yeah. I mean, it does seem like two conflicting needs. But it's, like, it does seem like you guys are also releasing new products and features also very fast.

So you're able to experiment and learn that way as well. I'd love to hear a little bit as a Haas alum how, if you were to come back in our shoes, like, how would you go about redoing Haas and what things would you do again if you were to return as a student? I'm shifting gears a little bit. I don't know if I would change a thing.

I loved my time here. I think it was, like, really transformative for me. I got to just be immersed.

You know, it's my first time living in California. I moved out from Chicago. And, you know, I love the Bay Area already.

But it was the first time that I really got to work at, you know, like, just incredible tech companies and around people who were so immersed in tech. So that was, like, so fun. But, you know, if I were to, like, in your shoes today, I would go build something.

I would have a portfolio of things. And I say this, like, not as just a product manager. I say this, like, if you're in finance, if you're in marketing, if you're going to go into corp dev, it doesn't matter.

I would have a portfolio. Like, if you want to get a job, you are going to have to demonstrate that you are AI native. And, you know, I think really having a track record of different kinds of projects you've worked on, and it's so easy to do it, but it means that you, like, kind of carve out time for yourself to experiment.

And to experiment with each other, like, pick a small project. I'll give you, like, ten examples of projects I've built in the last year. I built a project for my son.

I have a three-and-a-half-year-old. And I built a project with the OpenAI voice API to be able to basically, it's called, like, moon jar. You basically, like, every night record, like, a little audio memory.

Like, I built software for my wife to, because she doesn't like going to Berkeley Bowl or going on their app and stuff. I built, like, software to basically, like, do personal shopping for us. I built software for, you know, I built, like, a weekend project.

It was janky. Like, don't get me wrong. Like, you're never going to see this project.

But I think, like, kind of, like, using, like, there's never been a better time to build personal software. Like, my brother-in-law is interviewing at one of the big, like, OpenAI tech companies. And there's nothing on the Internet about how to do the project manager.

And there's nothing on the Internet about, like, how to interview. So I built him an app that is, like, a case study interview app. Like, and I built him, like, a date.

So a lot of this is, like, but I don't know that I could have done that a year ago. Right? It took me time to kind of, like, get really good at building again. And, you know, I have a software background.

Like, I've written a lot of software. But even then, I still was, like, rusty. And so don't get rusty.

That's probably my, like, best advice. Like, you have this just golden opportunity. Like, if I were to go back in time, I would spend more time in the engineering school.

I would spend more time in the D school. I would, like, really cultivate relationships across schools as well. Because I think it's just, like, this really, really magical opportunity to get to invest in yourself for two years, to get to invest in your community, and to learn.

And I guess the last thing I would say is, like, be alert at all. Like, just never think that you know. Because every single time, life will just come and, like, smack you on the head and be like, you actually have no idea.

I'm definitely inspired. And I will probably go home tonight and start building an agent. Love it.

I love this. I have a quick follow-up question to that. You talk a lot about building yourself.

For those of us in the audience, we would love to know, like, what AI tools are you using daily? How are you, like, you're building apps or whatnot. Like, could you talk us a little bit more through, like, how you're using AI exactly in your day-to-day life and, like, which tools you love to use? Yeah. So, right now, I'm a huge fan of cloud code.

I think the simplest expression of, you know, like, trying to convey what you're trying to do is through just, like, a command line. It seems intimidating, but I promise you there are some really good tutorials out there. And, like, my wife, who is not a developer, has started using cloud code and is building her app using cloud code.

So I promise you every single person in this room can learn how to use it. And the reason why I like it is I basically have built out all kinds of agents to help me, like, prep for anything. So every single time a new model comes out, like, the thing that I try to go do is build out a chief of staff because I just, like, hate doing busy work.

Like, pretty much, like, if I could, like, not ever have to fill out a status report of any kind, that would make me happy. And so that was, like, how I started. But then, so I created, like, an agent that filled out this – I have to do, like, an executive team meeting every single day with our staff and, like, give an update on top three projects, and I just hate doing it.

So I, like, built out the Slack agents, and I, you know, basically just – it goes and runs and updates it for me, and my boss has no idea that that's going on, so don't tell her. And then, you know, I – this is how I built out, like, a female triage agent. I built out a calendar triage agent.

I built out an agent that goes and reads newsletters for me and condenses it down to a thousand-word article. I built out an agent to prep for this discussion. I had to do podcasts, you know, like, just about once or twice a week right now.

So I built out a podcast prep agent. I built out, like, anything that you have to do semi-repetitively where it requires, like, a lot of context about you, you can go and build an agent for. And so – but it starts with, like, having one problem that you want to solve.

And, you know, taking – deciding what you want to take over two hours to solve that problem. It sounds like you have a huge team of agents. I have about, like, 25 agents at this point.

But it – I mean, I maybe started working on this, like, five months ago. I am going on a podcast this week. I'm going to show it off if anyone wants it.

It's called How I AI. Awesome. We'll definitely share that out.

We're almost at time. One final question for you. For those of us in the room who are interested in going into AI and are recruiting for AI, what do you recommend for what we should be looking for at the types of companies that we want to join for the future? Yeah, there's a great article by this guy Nikul Singh that I'll give a shout-out to.

But I think that he does a really nice job of giving a framework to the types of AI jobs right now, the types of AI tech companies. And I would say there's maybe a third category I'll talk about at the end. But there's obviously, like, AI-native companies.

So I think you can think of the foundational model companies as AI-native. You can think of, like, applied AI companies like Cursor or, you know, a lot of Carvey, a lot of, like, vertical AI. That's what I would say is, like, AI-native.

Then there's companies like Webflow, like Notion that were born in a different era that have, you know, definitely turned a corner around being AI-native at this point. And it's like a top-down mandate, this is who we are, this is who we're going to be. Those are the kinds of companies I would go and try to get into.

But I also think that there are a lot of great companies out there that are also, you know, like large companies. So, like, for example, I was talking to someone at Intuit. You don't think of Intuit as a company that is going to reinvent themselves with AI.

She's running a very high division. They're very, very AI-forward. And, you know, so I think a lot of it is, like, what are the top bets of the company? How have they set themselves up to go after those bets? Who have they attracted? What kind of talent have they attracted in order to, like, solve those problems? And then, you know, a lot of it is, like, who are you going to learn from? Because when you come out of this, you know, of this amazing community where you're, like, learning every single day from each other, you want to make sure that you're putting yourself into another community where you're also going to get to continue to learn.

And then, of course, there's, like, consulting and banking, and they're all trying to reinvent themselves with AI as well. So, you know, I don't think there's, like, any company that you're going to go and work for that is not reinventing themselves with AI. The way I would describe it is think about the innovators dilemma.

There's the normal distribution of people. And in any company, or, you know, just the world, like, there's going to be people that are the early adopters, that are in that, like, you know, kind of, like, segment.

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